The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Iranian authorities appointed an interim three-person panel to replace Ali Khamenei, the supreme leader killed by American and Israeli strikes. The "**leadership council**", formed on Sunday, consists of Masoud Pezeshkian, the president; Gholamhossein Mohseni Ejei, the head of the judiciary; and Alireza Arafi, a high-ranking cleric. They will govern until a new ruler is formally appointed by the Assembly of Experts, a group of 88 Islamic scholars.

After vowing to respond with its most destructive operation ever, **Iran's** military launched a fresh wave of retaliatory strikes. They fired missiles and drones across Israel and at Bahrain, Kuwait and Qatar, where America has military bases. Most were intercepted. But one hit a bomb shelter near **Jerusalem**, killing at least nine people. Meanwhile **America's armed forces** said three service members have been killed during operations.

Eight **oil-producing countries**—including Russia, Saudi Arabia and several Gulf States—announced that they will increase oil output by 206,000 barrels a day in April. The Organisation of the Petroleum Producing Countries and its partners have not boosted production since December. But analysts are sceptical that the

proposed hike will be enough to offset the disruption to global oil flows caused by the conflict.

At a special meeting of the **UN Security Council**, António Guterres, the secretary-general, condemned the attacks. He warned they risked igniting an uncontrollable chain of events “in the most volatile region of the world”. At the meeting, Russia said the strikes violated international law. Marco Rubio, America’s secretary of state, will speak on Sunday with his counterparts in the G7.

Hundreds of thousands of **air passengers** were stranded as carriers cancelled flights across the Middle East. Connecting airports, including in Abu Dhabi, Dubai and Doha, grounded all services. Airlines also diverted planes from the region. Meanwhile Iran’s navy is reportedly telling ships they are not allowed to use the **Strait of Hormuz**, a waterway through which a third of all seaborne oil travels.

In other news: The conflict between **Afghanistan** and **Pakistan** showed little sign of cooling, as Afghanistan said it had fired at Pakistani jets. **Ukrainian** officials suggested that **Russia** had agreed to American proposals for post-war security guarantees. In his first letter to shareholders, Greg Abel, **Berkshire Hathaway’s** newish boss, promised to follow a similar strategy to Warren Buffett, his legendary predecessor at the conglomerate.

Photograph: USS Abraham Lincoln (CVN 72)

What will America and Israel strike next?

The range of targets that America and Israel have hit since they began attacking Iran on Saturday has been wide. But the most important bomb was the one that killed Ali Khamenei, Iran's supreme leader. After his death, the list of targets is likely to change. In the coming hours and days America and Israel will go through a process known as "battle-damage assessment" to work out what they have destroyed, whom they have killed and which sites might need follow-up bombing.

Both countries will try to hit Iranian missile-launchers as they emerge from hidden positions, with the aim of pre-empting salvoes. If Iran succeeds in killing American personnel at military bases in the Persian Gulf, Donald Trump could intensify his campaign in response. Despite the uncertainty at the top of the Islamic regime, many days of war may still lie ahead.

Photograph: Getty Images

The threat to Gulf states

Iran wasted little time before lashing out at its Arab neighbours on Saturday. It fired missiles and drones at military bases in Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and the United Arab Emirates, all of which host American troops. Most of the attacks were swatted away by air defences. It caused more damage to civilian targets: drones hit Kuwait’s international airport and a residential tower in Bahrain; a luxury hotel in Dubai was set ablaze.

Gulf rulers had spent the past two months trying to convince Donald Trump not to strike Iran, fearing exactly this sort of retaliation. Oman tried to mediate talks over a nuclear deal that would prevent war. Those efforts failed. They are desperate to avoid a prolonged war, which could shatter their reputation as safe hubs for business and tourism. Some firms are already drawing up plans in case they have to evacuate staff. Yet the harder Iran hits Gulf states, the more it may end up pushing them into alignment with America.

Photograph: Imago

The war’s impact on energy prices

When Iran and Israel exchanged missiles last June, global oil prices jumped by 7%. The current conflict may have an even greater impact.

There are already reports that Iran’s Revolutionary Guard Corps are stopping ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz to the Persian Gulf. A complete closure of the waterway, through which 31% of all seaborne crude travels, could rapidly reduce supply worldwide. Meanwhile explosions have been heard on Kharg Island, Iran’s main oil-export terminal.

Analysts expect the price of a barrel to rise to $85-90 when markets open on Monday, up from $73 on Friday. Further disruption is possible. The Organisation of the Petroleum Exporting Countries may help matters by increasing production elsewhere; its members will meet on Sunday. But the longer the conflict drags on, the more likely it is to send energy markets reeling.

I’m glad you like adverbs — I adore them; they are the only qualifications I really much respect.

Henry James